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the top-two spot due to the Azzurri's superior goal difference.

Ukraine fought its way back through the playoff rounds, beating Bosnia and Herzegovina and Iceland with late goals to make it to the Euros for the fourth consecutive edition.

It has only one loss in its last ten games, which came against England in March 2023, and has won four out of its last five games.

Ukraine has been in an unfortunate war-torn state since the invasion by Russia, and this Euros is much more than just a tournament for its players.

With the devastating conditions at home, Ukraine will play for national pride and hope to give its fans a memorable run in the tournament. This patriotic feeling will act as a catalyst for its solid form.

Ukraine plays in a 4-2-3-1 formation with its prolific goal-scorer Artem Dovbyk leading the charge up front. Other notable players in the outfield are Arsenal's Oleksandr Zinchenko (above; right), controlling the game as the central defensive midfielder, and Chelsea winger Mykhailo Mudryk (above; left) running down the left flank.

The performance of Andriy Lunin between the sticks, who has been exceptional for Real Madrid, will also determine Ukraine's chances of progressing to the knockout stages.

Slovakia and Romania might struggle

Slovakia and Romania are the weaker of the four teams in their group, making the clash between them crucial for both sides.

The Slovaks ended the qualifying round second in its group behind Portugal and look a bit stronger with a few notable names in its ranks. Napoli midfielder Stanislav Labotka will be the key player controlling the game for the Falcons, and PSG's centre-back Milan Skriniar will command the backline.

Unlike Slovakia, Romania lacks star power in its squad but surprised everyone by topping its qualification group ahead of Switzerland.

The 22-year-old Spurs centre-back Radu Dragusin is the most important name in its young squad. Captain Nicolae Stanciu has 14 goals for his country and will be the key attacking threat for his side.

Knockouts prediction:

Belgium and Ukraine should be the clear favourites to go through to the knockouts based on both teams' strength on paper and current form.

With four of the best third-placed teams set to qualify for the knockouts, both Romania and Slovakia could make it beyond the group stages, with the latter having a better chance.

PLAYERS TO WATCH OUT FOR



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JEREMY DOKU

Doku has seven goals and nine assists for Manchester City this season and has been influential on the flanks. His dribbling prowess and ability to create scoring chances from wide areas make him a crucial player for Belgium.



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ARTEM DOVBYK

Dovbyk ended the La Liga season as its top-scorer (24). He helped Girona finish third and qualify for the Champions League for the first time in the club's history. Although Dovbyk has only scored two goals for Ukraine in the qualifiers, he has the potential to be one of the highest scorers of Euro 2024.